

Matthew 24: Near and Far Fulfillment

The Mountain Peaks of Prophecy

Introduction

Matthew 24 is one of the most important—and most debated—prophetic passages in Scripture. Jesus' Olivet Discourse speaks of Jerusalem, the temple, persecution, tribulation, His coming, and the end of the age. The challenge is determining how these events relate to one another.

Were Jesus' words fulfilled entirely in the first century when Jerusalem and the temple were destroyed in A.D. 70? Do they refer entirely to events still future? Or does the prophecy contain both a historical fulfillment and a greater fulfillment yet to come?

The Near/Far interpretation provides a way of understanding this apparent tension.

The principle can be illustrated by looking at a mountain range from a great distance. The peaks may appear to stand almost side by side, forming what looks like one continuous ridge. Yet when we draw closer, we discover valleys separating them—sometimes great distances that were invisible from afar.

Prophecy can work in a similar way. Events separated by significant periods of time may appear together within the prophetic perspective.

In Matthew 24, the destruction of Jerusalem in A.D. 70 can be understood as a genuine historical fulfillment of Jesus' warning while also serving as a foreshadowing of a greater and final fulfillment associated with the Tribulation and the visible return of Christ.

The purpose of this study is not to force every verse into one particular period, but to examine how the historical and ultimate horizons of Jesus' prophecy may fit together.

1. The Setting: Two Questions, One Discourse

Matthew tells us that Jesus had just predicted the destruction of the temple:

“Truly I tell you, not one stone here will be left on another; every one will be thrown down.” — Matthew 24:2

Later, while Jesus was sitting on the Mount of Olives, His disciples came to Him privately and asked:

“Tell us,” they said, “when will these things happen, and what will be the sign of Your coming and of the end of the age?” — Matthew 24:3

Their question contains two closely related concerns:

1. **When will the temple be destroyed?**
2. **What will be the sign of Christ's coming and of the end of the age?**

This is important because the disciples' questions naturally bring together a near historical event and a future eschatological expectation.

The Near/Far interpretation therefore understands Jesus' answer as addressing both horizons. His words speak meaningfully to the first-century disciples while also extending beyond their immediate circumstances toward the consummation of the age.

2. The Mountain Peaks Principle

The Near/Far principle does not require us to assume that every prophetic statement has two completely separate fulfillments. Rather, it recognizes that Scripture sometimes presents an earlier event that anticipates or foreshadows a later and greater fulfillment.

The destruction of Jerusalem provides a striking example.

A.D. 70 was a genuine historical judgment. Jerusalem was surrounded, the temple was destroyed, and enormous suffering followed. Yet the language Jesus uses later in the discourse reaches beyond that event.

The historical judgment becomes a prophetic pattern.

Earlier judgments can foreshadow greater judgments still to come:

Historical fulfillment → prophetic foreshadowing → ultimate fulfillment

A.D. 70 does not have to be dismissed as irrelevant to Matthew 24 simply because the passage also points beyond it. Nor does the future fulfillment require us to ignore the fact that Jesus was speaking to people living in the first century.

The mountain peaks can be real peaks while still being separated by valleys.

3. An Old Testament Pattern: Near and Far Fulfillment

The Near/Far interpretation is not a method invented to explain Matthew 24. The Old Testament itself provides examples in which prophecy has an immediate historical setting while also pointing beyond that setting toward a greater fulfillment.

One of the clearest examples is Daniel's prophecy concerning the "*abomination of desolation*." Daniel 11:31 describes the desecration of the sanctuary associated with Antiochus IV Epiphanes in **167 B.C., hundreds of years after Daniel wrote his prophecy**. Daniel 12:11 uses the same

language of the removal of the regular sacrifice and the setting up of the abomination, but places it within a future period of unparalleled distress.

Centuries later, Jesus specifically referred to Daniel's prophecy:

“So when you see standing in the holy place the ‘abomination of desolation,’ spoken of through the prophet Daniel...” — Matthew 24:15

Jesus' use of Daniel demonstrates that the historical desecration did not exhaust the prophetic significance of Daniel's words. The historical event became a pattern pointing toward a greater fulfillment.

The same principle appears elsewhere in Scripture. Isaiah's prophecy concerning Immanuel arose within the immediate circumstances of Isaiah's own generation, yet Matthew identifies its ultimate fulfillment in the birth of Christ (Isaiah 7:14; Matthew 1:22–23). Joel's prophecy concerning the outpouring of God's Spirit found fulfillment at Pentecost, yet portions of the prophecy concerning cosmic signs and the day of the Lord extend beyond that event (Joel 2:28–32; Acts 2:16–21).

These examples demonstrate an important biblical principle: **an initial fulfillment does not necessarily exhaust a prophecy's ultimate significance**. A historical event can be both a genuine fulfillment and a foreshadowing of something greater to come.

The Near fulfillment is real. The Far fulfillment is real. The first can point toward the second without being identical to it, and the second may itself point toward a third—as appears to be the case with the abomination of desolation.

This provides a biblical foundation for understanding Matthew 24 through the Near/Far perspective.

4. The Beginning of Birth Pains

Jesus begins by warning His disciples not to be deceived. He speaks of false christs and false prophets, wars and rumors of wars, famines, earthquakes, persecution, hatred of His followers, and the worldwide proclamation of the gospel.

Jesus describes these things as *“the beginning of birth pains”* (Matthew 24:8).

The birth-pain analogy is significant. Birth pains are real events, but they also anticipate something greater. As labor progresses, the pains become more intense and increasingly point toward the approaching birth.

In the first century, these conditions were already present. The early church experienced persecution, famine, earthquakes, false teachers, and opposition to the gospel. Yet the same pattern can also characterize the period leading toward Christ's return.

The point is not that every war, earthquake, or famine is itself a prophetic sign identifying the end. Jesus warns against that kind of simplistic interpretation. Rather, these are the **birth pains**—conditions that characterize the age and intensify as the final events approach.

5. The Abomination of Desolation

One of the most important prophetic statements in Matthew 24 occurs when Jesus says:

“So when you see standing in the holy place the ‘abomination of desolation,’ spoken of through the prophet Daniel...” — Matthew 24:15

The phrase comes from Daniel.

Daniel 9:27, 11:31, and 12:11 connect the abomination with the cessation of sacrifice, the defilement of the sanctuary, and a defined period of intense oppression.

Daniel 7 adds another dimension. It describes a blasphemous ruler—the *little horn*—who speaks against God, persecutes the saints, and exercises authority for “*a time, times, and half a time*” (Daniel 7:25).

The abomination of desolation therefore appears within a larger prophetic pattern involving:

- A rebellious ruler
- Profanation of the sanctuary
- Opposition to God
- Persecution
- A defined period of tribulation

There was a historical precedent in the desecration of the temple under Antiochus IV Epiphanes. But Jesus' reference to Daniel demonstrates that the prophetic theme was not exhausted by Antiochus.

The question, then, is whether A.D. 70 represents the ultimate fulfillment or whether it foreshadows something greater.

The Near/Far interpretation, supported by the clear revelation given in Scripture, understands it as the latter.

6. The Command to Flee: Two Contexts, One Principle

Jesus' warning is urgent:

“So when you see standing in the holy place the ‘abomination of desolation,’ spoken of through the prophet Daniel... then let those who are in Judea flee to the mountains.” — Matthew 24:15–16

Mark records the same basic warning:

“So when you see the abomination of desolation standing where it should not be...” — Mark 13:14

The instruction is unmistakable:

Flee.

Do not delay. Do not return for possessions. Leave immediately.

This establishes the abomination as a decisive prophetic signal.

Yet Luke records Jesus' warning in notably different language:

“When you see Jerusalem surrounded by armies, you will know that her desolation is near. Then let those who are in Judea flee to the mountains.” — Luke 21:20–21

Luke's description corresponds closely to the historical events of A.D. 70. Roman armies surrounded Jerusalem. The city was destroyed, and the temple was demolished, fulfilling Jesus' earlier prediction that not one stone would remain upon another.

If the command to flee in A.D. 70 depended upon the actual desecration of the temple occurring at the very end of the siege, the warning would have come too late to provide the kind of immediate escape Jesus described. Luke's *“Jerusalem surrounded by armies”* provides an observable and actionable warning for the first-century disciples.

Matthew and Mark, however, preserve the language of Daniel concerning the *“abomination of desolation”* and connect it with events that extend into the Great Tribulation.

The Gospel accounts therefore need not be viewed as contradictory.

Luke gives a particularly clear historical application to A.D. 70, while Matthew and Mark preserve language that reaches beyond A.D. 70 toward the ultimate fulfillment.

The principle remains the same: **when God provides the warning, respond immediately.**

7. The Great Tribulation

Jesus then says:

“For then there will be great tribulation, such as has not been from the beginning of the world until now, nor ever will be again.” — Matthew 24:21

The destruction of Jerusalem in A.D. 70 was horrific. Yet Jesus' language points toward something even greater:

“such as has not been from the beginning of the world until now, nor ever will be again.”

The Near/Far interpretation therefore recognizes A.D. 70 as a genuine and terrible fulfillment while understanding the passage to point beyond it toward a final period of unprecedented tribulation.

This corresponds with the broader prophetic testimony of Scripture. Daniel speaks of an unparalleled period of distress, while Revelation 6–19 describes judgments of extraordinary scope.

Jesus' words therefore move from the historical judgment of Jerusalem toward a climactic period that precedes His return.

8. The Cosmic Signs and the Coming of the Son of Man

The strongest indication that Matthew 24 extends beyond A.D. 70 comes in the verses that follow:

“Immediately after the tribulation of those days: ‘The sun will be darkened, and the moon will not give its light; the stars will fall from the sky, and the powers of the heavens will be shaken.’”
— Matthew 24:29

Then Jesus declares:

“Then will appear the sign of the Son of Man in heaven, and all the tribes of the earth will mourn. They will see the Son of Man coming on the clouds of heaven, with power and great glory.” — Matthew 24:30

And:

“And He will send out His angels with a loud trumpet call, and they will gather His elect from the four winds, from one end of the heavens to the other.” — Matthew 24:31

The language here is difficult to confine to the destruction of Jerusalem.

The coming of the Son of Man is visible. The nations see Him. The heavens are shaken. The elect are gathered.

The imagery reaches back to Daniel 7 and forward to the final return of Christ.

Whatever historical significance A.D. 70 possesses, it does not exhaust these promises. Here the prophetic horizon opens unmistakably toward the consummation of the age.

9. The Man of Lawlessness and the Final Desecration

Paul provides additional insight into the prophetic pattern in 2 Thessalonians 2. He describes a coming “*man of lawlessness*” who exalts himself against God, opposes everything called God, takes his seat in the temple of God, and proclaims himself to be God.

Paul writes:

“He will oppose and exalt himself above every so-called god or object of worship. So he will seat himself in the temple of God and proclaim himself to be God.” — 2 Thessalonians 2:4

This closely parallels Daniel's blasphemous ruler and Jesus' reference to the abomination of desolation.

It therefore provides another reason to understand the ultimate fulfillment as involving a future personal agent of rebellion.

The historical destruction of Jerusalem does not eliminate this future expectation. Instead, A.D. 70 can be understood as a historical foreshadowing of a final confrontation in which rebellion against God reaches its climax.

10. The Temple and the Prophetic Sanctuary

The temple question is important because Daniel's prophecy, Jesus' reference to the “*holy place*,” Paul's description of the man of lawlessness, and Revelation's vision of the temple all point toward a **literal sanctuary in Jerusalem**.

Daniel's prophecies speak of sacrifice, the cessation of sacrifice, and the desecration of the sanctuary (Daniel 9:27; 11:31; 12:11). These descriptions naturally imply a functioning temple in which sacrifices are taking place.

Jesus likewise speaks of the “*abomination of desolation*” standing in the “*holy place*” (Matthew 24:15). His warning describes a specific event occurring at a specific place and commands those in Judea to flee when they see it.

Revelation 11 likewise describes the temple being measured while Jerusalem is being trampled by the nations (Revelation 11:1–2).

Taken together, these passages provide a strong biblical basis for understanding the future prophetic temple **literally rather than symbolically**.

The New Testament does use the word *temple* symbolically when referring to believers and the Church. But that does not require us to reinterpret every prophetic reference to the temple as symbolic. Context determines meaning.

The temple described in these prophetic passages is associated with **sacrifice, a holy place, desecration, Jerusalem, the man of lawlessness, and the events immediately preceding the Great Tribulation**. These details point toward a real sanctuary in Jerusalem.

The implication is significant: **a temple must exist for these prophecies to be fulfilled in the manner Scripture describes.** Therefore, the Near/Far interpretation points toward a future rebuilding of the temple in Jerusalem before the ultimate fulfillment of the abomination of desolation.

A.D. 70 demonstrated the historical reality of Jesus' warning concerning Jerusalem and the temple. The prophetic passages point beyond that destruction to a future sanctuary and a final desecration associated with the end of the age.

11. Revelation and the Final Expression of the Abomination

Revelation expands the picture.

Revelation 13 describes the beast exercising authority and an image being established that becomes associated with worship and allegiance.

The beast's authority lasts forty-two months—three and a half years, corresponding closely with the prophetic time periods found in Daniel.

The parallels are striking:

- A blasphemous ruler
- Corrupted worship
- Desecration
- Centralized authority
- Persecution
- A defined period of oppression

The final expression of the abomination is therefore not merely political.

It is fundamentally spiritual.

It represents the attempted usurpation of God's authority and the demand that humanity give to a creature the worship that belongs to the Creator.

12. “This Generation”

Jesus concludes this portion of the discourse with a statement that has generated considerable discussion:

“Truly I tell you, this generation will not pass away until all these things have happened.” — Matthew 24:34

The interpretive differences surrounding this verse create difficulty in determining precisely how Jesus' words relate to the Near and Far horizons of the prophecy. Several understandings have

been proposed, including the first-century generation, which certainly saw Jesus' words fulfilled in their own time, the Jewish people as a continuing people, and the generation that witnesses the final sequence of events.

Jesus also gave a significant prophecy concerning Jerusalem:

“Jerusalem will be trampled by the Gentiles until the times of the Gentiles are fulfilled.” —
Luke 21:24

For many centuries following the destruction of Jerusalem and the dispersion of the Jewish people, Jerusalem remained under Gentile rule. Then, in **1967**, Israel captured East Jerusalem, including the Old City, during the Six-Day War. Israel subsequently established its control over the city and regards Jerusalem as its united capital.

This is significant because Jerusalem stands at the center of numerous end-time prophecies. While 1967 may not be presented as a direct fulfillment of a specific prediction in Matthew 24, the restoration of Jewish control over Jerusalem represents a remarkable development in the prophetic landscape. **After nearly two thousand years without Jewish sovereignty over the city, Israel again exercised control over Jerusalem, including the Temple Mount.** It may therefore be viewed as an important historical milestone in the movement toward the conditions described in the final chapters of biblical prophecy.

Could 1967 mark the beginning of the generation Jesus referred to? It is possible, but Scripture does not give us sufficient grounds to establish a seventy- or eighty-year countdown from that event. Psalm 90:10 says, *“The length of our days is seventy years—or eighty if we are strong.”* Some prophetic interpreters therefore consider seventy to eighty years as a possible generational framework.

Yet Matthew may be using the word *generation* in a more general sense rather than specifying a precise number of years. **Only time will ultimately tell.**

I believe the most significant marker may be the generation that witnesses the final sequence of signs Jesus describes—beginning with the birth pains and the preaching of the gospel to all nations, followed by the appearance of the Antichrist, the rebuilding of the temple, and the confirmation of a seven-year covenant involving Israel. The breaking of that covenant and the cessation of sacrifice **culminate in the abomination of desolation**, followed by the Great Tribulation, the cosmic signs, the visible appearing of the Son of Man, and the gathering of His elect.

Certainly, the generation that witnesses the abomination of desolation will be alive to see His return. Jesus' statement therefore carries both urgency and certainty: **the generation that sees these final things unfold will not pass away before all that He has promised is fulfilled.**

The entire discussion can be summarized simply:

Passage	Near Fulfillment	Far Fulfillment
Matthew 24:4–14	Birth pains experienced in the first century	Increasing global distress before Christ's return
Matthew 24:15	Historical desecration and destruction	Final abomination associated with the Antichrist
Matthew 24:21	Catastrophic suffering in Jerusalem	Worldwide and unprecedented Great Tribulation
Matthew 24:29–31	Foreshadowing prophetic imagery	Visible Second Coming and gathering of the elect

The pattern is not:

A.D. 70 OR the end times.

It is:

A.D. 70 → historical fulfillment and foreshadowing → final fulfillment.

This is the heart of the Near/Far interpretation.

Earlier judgment establishes a pattern that points toward ultimate judgment.

Jerusalem's destruction was real.

Its prophetic significance is larger than itself.

14. The Nature of the Final Crisis

In its ultimate expression, the crisis described by Jesus is not merely political or military.

It is profoundly spiritual.

The abomination of desolation represents:

- The corruption of true worship
- The usurpation of divine authority
- The exaltation of a human ruler against God
- The persecution of God's people
- The beginning of unprecedented tribulation

Paul warns that the final rebellion may arise under conditions of apparent stability:

“While people are saying, ‘Peace and security,’ destruction will come upon them suddenly, like labor pains on a pregnant woman, and they will not escape.” — 1 Thessalonians 5:3

The final crisis therefore involves more than war.

It involves deception.

It involves worship.

It involves allegiance.

And ultimately, it involves the question of **who has the right to rule**.

15. Watchfulness and Readiness

Jesus did not give the Olivet Discourse merely to satisfy curiosity about future events. He gave it to prepare His followers.

He concludes:

“Therefore keep watch, because you do not know the day on which your Lord will come.” —
Matthew 24:42

Prophecy is therefore not primarily about constructing elaborate timelines.

It is about **readiness**.

The believer is called to remain faithful, discerning, watchful, and prepared.

Whatever the precise sequence of future events, the certainty of Christ's return should affect the way we live today.

Conclusion

Jesus' Olivet Discourse speaks both to history and to the future. The destruction of Jerusalem in A.D. 70 was a genuine fulfillment of His warning, yet it does not exhaust the prophetic scope of Matthew 24.

The abomination of desolation, the unparalleled Great Tribulation, the cosmic disturbances, the visible coming of the Son of Man, and the gathering of the elect point toward a greater consummation still to come.

The Mountain Peaks Principle provides a useful way of understanding this relationship. From a distance, the peaks appear close together. From closer perspective, valleys separate them. So it can be with prophecy.

The destruction of Jerusalem was not merely an isolated historical event. It became a prophetic pattern—a genuine fulfillment that foreshadows a greater and final fulfillment at the end of the age.

The important point is not that we can identify every valley between the prophetic peaks with certainty. The important point is that **Jesus' words will be fulfilled.**

History has already demonstrated the reliability of His warning concerning Jerusalem, and Scripture assures us that His final promises will likewise be fulfilled.

The same Christ who warned of Jerusalem's destruction promised that He would come again in power and glory.

Therefore, the proper response to Matthew 24 is not merely speculation.

It is readiness.

Watch.

Be faithful.

Do not be deceived.

And be ready for the coming of the Son of Man.